5
JUNTA CURFEW

14 MARCH 2020

INDIA | 88 ACTIVE CASES | 2 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,14,719 ACTIVE CASES | 5,869 DEATHS

A renowned Washington D.C.-based epidemiologist gave select media interviews painting a dire picture of the coronavirus situation in India and the doomsday which lay ahead for the country. He predicted using a mathematical simulation model that India was likely to be the next COVID-19 hotspot, with 40–50 per cent of Indians eventually infected by the month of July 2020, thus amounting to 300–500 million people on the higher end. He also said that about four to eight million patients would require ICU beds which we only had about 70-something thousands of. This prediction was based on his ‘IndiaSim model’, a generic simulation, mathematical model of the Indian population which his team had been using for other infectious diseases and had adapted to coronavirus specifics. In order to produce India-specific predictions, the model was further adapted to include Indian demographic data such as age and medical facilities data. He stated in his interviews that the UK had recently admitted that they had underestimated the number of cases by a factor of 12 and insisted that India must give itself a similar report card. In his media bytes, he also imparted several suggestions to the GoI and insisted that they immediately consider them in order to allay his predicted apocalyptic situation. His choice of interviewers was controversial and more often than not, he let the interviewer get the better of what should have been a neutral scientific conversation by politically charging the discussion. However, intrigued by his confidence in the predictions, the PMO invited him to make a presentation explaining the model behind arriving at those figures. If there